Extra Watchers Will Be on Duty at Polling Places on Election Day

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When Americans vote in the **midterm elections** on November 3, extra watchers will be on duty at many **polling places**. The U.S. Department of Justice, or DOJ, plans to send about 1,000 **election monitors** to all 50 states. That is more than double the number used in the 2022 midterms.

Monitors have a quiet job. They stand back, watch how voting is run, and report what they see. Their purpose is to make sure **voting-rights laws** are followed, so nobody is wrongly turned away or scared off from voting. "They're there to just do as their name suggests, which is to observe," said Stacey Young, a former DOJ lawyer who has been a monitor three times. Monitors never run the voting, and the department says they have been told clearly not to **interfere**.

Why are some state officials worried this year? The effort is much bigger than usual. David Becker, a former DOJ voting-rights attorney, called the scale "not normal," but said he is "not particularly concerned." Also, **prosecutors** will be allowed to serve as monitors this year, something long-standing rules did not allow. A senior DOJ official said monitors will focus on busy areas and places that have had problems with language or disability access.

The monitors will visit only Election Day **polling places**, not early-voting sites.

Word Treasure

midterm elections -- National elections held halfway through a president's four years in office.

polling places -- The places where people go to cast their votes in an election.

election monitors -- People who watch how voting is run and report what they see, without running the voting themselves.

voting-rights laws -- Laws that protect people's right to vote and stop anyone from being wrongly turned away.

prosecutors -- Government lawyers who bring cases against people accused of breaking the law.

interfere -- To get in the way of something or try to change how it is being done.

Background you need

In the United States, the Department of Justice can send election monitors to polling places to watch how voting is run.

Monitors never run the voting and must not interfere; they stand back, observe and report what they see.

Their purpose is to make sure voting-rights laws are followed, so nobody is wrongly turned away or scared off from voting.

Break it down

WHO: The U.S. Department of Justice, its election monitors, and state officials reacting to the plan

WHAT: The DOJ plans to send about 1,000 election monitors to polling places in all 50 states for the November 3 midterm elections

WHERE: Election Day polling places across all 50 states, focusing on busy areas and places that have had language or disability access problems

WHY: To make sure voting-rights laws are followed so nobody is wrongly turned away or scared off from voting, though some officials worry because the effort is much bigger than usual

Why it matters

Fair voting rules protect everyone's voice in an election, including the grown-ups who vote on things that shape your school and neighborhood.

Test what you remember

1. About how many election monitors does the Department of Justice plan to send?

- (A) About 1,000
- (B) About 100
- (C) About 10,000
- (D) About 50

2. What is an election monitor's main job?

- (A) To tell people who to vote for
- (B) To run the voting at polling places
- (C) To watch how voting is run and report what they see
- (D) To count all the ballots

3. How does this year's number of monitors compare with the 2022 midterms?

- (A) It is more than double
- (B) It is exactly the same
- (C) It is about the same
- (D) It is much smaller

4. What is new about who can serve as a monitor this year?

- (A) Monitors can run the voting this year
- (B) Children can serve as monitors
- (C) Only new voters can be monitors
- (D) Prosecutors will be allowed to serve as monitors

5. Where will the monitors focus their attention?

- (A) Only in one state
- (B) Only in small towns
- (C) Busy areas and places that have had problems with language or disability access
- (D) Only at early-voting sites

6. Which places will the monitors NOT visit?

- (A) Busy voting areas
- (B) Polling places in the 50 states
- (C) Election Day polling places
- (D) Early-voting sites

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Stacey Young, a former DOJ lawyer who has been a monitor three times: She said monitors are there to do what their name suggests: observe.

2. David Becker, a former DOJ voting-rights attorney: He called the scale of this year's effort 'not normal,' but said he is not particularly concerned.

3. Some state officials: They are worried this year because the monitoring effort is much bigger than usual.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):